



Let's Play with Emacs CLI

Text editors are very important tools for developers. In this article, I am going to discuss the basics of the Emacs text editor, which I have found very powerful.

Emacs was developed by Richard Stallman under the GNU project. Stallman published his Emacs source code under a free *copyleft* software licence, called the Emacs Public License. He used the C and Emacs Lisp languages in creating this editor. Emacs is also known as the 'King Of Editors' because of its features. The Emacs environment doesn't seem intuitive at first glance, and it doesn't work like other editors and word processors. Still, learning Emacs doesn't have to be difficult.

The latest version of Emacs is 23.2 (just released on the 8th of May). You can check your

(installed) version by typing `emacs --version` in a terminal. Emacs is cross-platform; I have tried it on Windows too.

Emacs was designed keeping in mind that users shouldn't have to waste their time picking up the mouse to click on a GUI widget to get something to happen. Thus, Emacs has two modes: GUI and CLI (command-line interface). Run the command `emacs` in your terminal window, to see the graphical mode (shown in Figure 1), which can be useful if you are not too familiar with the CLI and terminal. It can also be launched from your desktop manager's applications menu.